

Dualism

What is appealing about dualism? Why would people believe in this split between the non-physical mind and the physical body?

Let's start with the basics: how do you know that you are not dreaming right now?

See... We might only believe our bodies are real while, in fact, we are actually just a brain on a bench that someone else is prodding with electrodes, simulating the physical reality that we perceive. There is no way of knowing. We can say that the physical world is 99.99999% likely to be real, but we can never say with 100% certainty that it is.

However... It is not an illusion to say that we are experiencing our thoughts. The existence of your mind is irrefutably proven by your experience of your thoughts. We cannot be certain about the rest of existence, but the fact that you are thinking right now means that we can say with 100% certainty that the conscious entity that is you is real.

So, where does that leave us? Our minds = 100% real. The rest of reality = 99.999999% likely to be real.

The attraction of Dualism can be summarised like this: we cannot prove the body, but we cannot refute the mind.

The Non-Physical Mind

Everything up until now hopefully makes rational sense: we are 100% certain that our minds exist because we are thinking, and we could only be thinking if our minds exist. However, we cannot prove anything else exists because there is a tiny, tiny, tiny chance that it could all be a trick.

Let's pretend that we are living in that 0.000001% chance that the rest of the world is all a trick. It turns out that your brain is actually on a bench somewhere and what you think is real is actually a stray cat licking your frontal lobe, causing you to hallucinate reality. Everything in this world that you know and love is actually just the saliva from little Mitsy's tongue, dripping down your neural pathways.

Well, if that's the case, then the dualist has cause for celebration! They were right! Your mind **MUST** exist in a way that nothing else does. Why? Well, now that we know that your brain is on a table being licked by a cat, the same logic applies as before: there's a 0.000001% chance **THAT'S** just an illusion, too.

So, the Dualist says, nothing physical is 100% certain to exist. However, because you are thinking then you can be 100% certain that your mind exists.. But what is your mind? If it's physical, like your brain, then we cannot be certain it exists. But we know for a fact that your mind definitely does exist. Therefore, the dualist says, your mind must be non-physical!

Problem solved!

How Do You Touch Something That Doesn't Exist?

Before you log off your computer and try to figure out a way of getting Mitsy to lick the part of your brain which simulates unlimited pogs, or whatever it is that you kids collect these days, I'm afraid there is a problem: if your thoughts are non-physical, then how could they influence your physical behaviour?

The Dualist has a philosophy-breaking problem here: we can't say that our thoughts are non-physical but at some point they become physical. As silly as this all might sound, we're not dealing with science fiction right now, we're legitimately trying to understand what the difference is between our minds and the rest of the world. It doesn't make sense to have something non-physical that is physically influential. We can go a step further, even: it doesn't really make sense to say that something non-physical exists!

The word 'physical' refers to properties we can measure: mass, energy, wavelength, frequency, etc. The phrase 'non-physical' is getting away with a pretty outrageous claim at the moment: how can something that does not physically exist be said to exist at all? It makes much more sense to simply say that everything that exists is physical.

On the other hand, the dualist cannot abandon the idea that our thoughts are non-physical: the whole point is that anything physical could simply be a dream or an illusion. If our minds are also physical then they might not be real. But we know our minds are real because we're thinking!

At this point, it seems we need to admit that dualism is illogical. However, with their dying breath, the dualist whispers to us to remember their initial point: your mind is the **only thing** that 100% definitely exists. That your mind exists is the only thing that you can know for absolute certain: that is the philosophical legacy of dualism.

Dualism might be a load of rubbish, but it has proven one thing that remains true to this day: the only thing that you can know for 100% certain is that your mind exists. Everything else might be a lie, but if you are thinking then you are existing.

Physicalism

The physicalist says this:

Mental states depend on physical states. To put it more firmly: mental states **are** physical states. There is nothing about the mind that cannot be understood through a physical explanation. Or so they say.

Unlike the dualist, the physicalist is not interested in making you doubt your own thoughts. The physicalist just says that your brain is physical and therefore your thoughts are physical. Our thoughts and personalities are an influential cocktail of genetics, chemicals, electricity, and well-trodden neural pathways.

Let's Clone You

Imagine that I have developed an advanced cloning machine using the money I receive from my high school teacher salary.

Now, imagine that you have consented to being put into that cloning machine. You

go in and after a few seconds there is a very hot, bright, green light that seems to go right through you. A sound, like a glitching video, surrounds you as the machine envelopes you, copying all the information from the deepest recesses of your mind and body.

My cloning machine perfectly replicates every single atom of you.

The other side of the machine cracks open: your clone is ready!

The question is: who comes out? The physicalist proudly says that it is a perfect copy of you in every single way. Everything is physical and, if my machine perfectly copied every single detail of your physical information, then what comes out is a perfect copy of you.

One issue, though... What about the 'you' bit of you? If everything is physical, then will your consciousness be replicated in the clone as well? If so, will you be able to feel both bodies at once?

That seems unlikely. What seems more likely is that the new version of you will be indiscernibly you, even to them. But... It won't be you, will it? It will be a copy of you, with fake memories from a history they never experienced. Let's pretend you broke your arm when you were a kid and now you can't bend it properly. Well, they can't either: except they never broke their arm. They only think that happened to them. But it didn't. It happened to you.

So, even though they are a perfect copy of you they are not actually you... So, they're not a perfect copy of you? How *do* we make a perfect copy of you, then?

The Problem of 'Hard Consciousness'

There's a much bigger problem here for the physicalist than it seems, one that the dualist never had to worry about: 'Hard Consciousness'.

Your consciousness, the bit of you that is thinking and feeling as you're reading this, doesn't seem to be able to be copied or moved. When we say 'hard consciousness', we mean the bit of you that can currently say 'I am thinking and therefore I exist'. It seems like, no matter what we do, that part of you that is really and truly you, who is reading this right now, cannot be copied. But if we cannot clone your consciousness, then... is it physical?

Hold on hold on, let's just all calm down. Perhaps we could say that, if we perfectly cloned you, you would start experiencing both minds at once. That seems unlikely, but then again so does perfect cloning! Let's imagine that we perfectly clone you, consciousness and all. You wake up in a second body, while still experiencing your current body. You've got two brains and two bodies now and it's sort of hard, but it also somehow works.

Well, wait a second, now we have the old non-physical problem again—how are your two minds linked? No, this is starting to get a bit weird.

It seems more likely that your clone will have a copy of your mind. They will be you, for now, but over time they will gradually become their own, unique, version of you.

But then, of course, they're not a perfect copy, are they? Your clone is actually a brand-new person with a brand-new consciousness that has never existed before.

So, we ask the physicalist: if everything is physical, then why does it seem like consciousness has properties that no other physical thing has?

It might surprise you to discover, but nobody knows the answer to this question. The problem of 'hard consciousness' is still unanswered in all of neuroscience.

Want to know more? Look up, 'Qualia.'